



Psychology 101: Operant Conditioning in Everyday Life — A Full Case-Study Session

Psychology 101 • Psychology

COURSE-OBJ.PSY101.2

Apply operant conditioning terms accurately to real scenarios, correctly identifying reinforcement vs. punishment and positive vs. negative in each case. A complete 90-minute session packet with warm-up, guided practice, partner/lab work, independent practice, extension work, assessment, and a full answer key.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan the session

Course and objective

Psychology 101 · Psychology; COURSE-OBJ.PSY101.2 — Identify reinforcement and punishment (positive/negative) in real behavior-change scenarios and distinguish operant conditioning from classical conditioning.

What is included

Cover; instructor guide; key-term and concept preview; original reading or worked examples; warm-up (2 items); guided practice with organizer (4 items); partner/lab discussion (3 items); independent practice (6 items); small-group extension work (4 items); assessment; complete answer key; access and sources page.

Suggested pacing (90-minute session)

Warm-up 8 min · read both case files + vocabulary 15 min · guided quadrant organizer 18 min · partner case discussion 18 min · independent practice 22 min · extension work 5 min · assessment 4 min.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from the answer key, or distribute through a secure LMS. Review the reading/examples and organizer before class. No paid textbook or app is required.

Student directions

Read or work through the material carefully. Support every answer with evidence, work shown, or clear reasoning.



Before you begin

Key terms

operant conditioning — learning where consequences change how often a behavior happens

positive — something is added following the behavior

negative — something is removed following the behavior

reinforcement — a consequence that increases a behavior

punishment — a consequence that decreases a behavior

extinction — a behavior decreasing because reinforcement stops

Concept focus

In operant conditioning, a consequence that follows a behavior changes how often that behavior happens again. "Positive" and "negative" describe whether something is added or removed, not whether the consequence feels good or bad. Positive reinforcement adds something to increase a behavior (a bonus for finishing early). Negative reinforcement removes something unpleasant to increase a behavior (a seatbelt chime stops once you buckle up). Positive punishment adds something to decrease a behavior (a fine for speeding). Negative punishment removes something to decrease a behavior (losing phone privileges). This differs from classical conditioning, where two stimuli are paired (a sound and food) rather than a behavior being followed by a consequence.

Model 1 — Sorting the four quadrants

A dog sits on command and gets a treat (behavior increases) — positive reinforcement, since a treat was added. A driver buckles up and the chime stops (behavior increases) — negative reinforcement, since an unpleasant sound was removed.

Model 2 — Distinguishing punishment from reinforcement by outcome

A worker is late and loses a bonus (behavior of lateness should decrease) — negative punishment, something was removed. A worker is late and gets a formal write-up (behavior should decrease) — positive punishment, something was added. Reinforcement always aims to increase a behavior; punishment always aims to decrease one.

WARM-UP

Warm-up

Answer using what you already know or recall from the previous session.

1. In Case File 1, classify what happened to Team A using the correct two-word operant conditioning term, and explain using "added vs. removed."

2. In Case File 1, classify what happened to Team B using the correct two-word term, and explain using "added vs. removed."



Case File 1: The Late-Arrival Problem

At Riverside Logistics, dock workers had been clocking in late all month. The shift manager, Dana, tried two different approaches with two different teams to see what would actually change the behavior, rather than guessing.

With Team A, Dana announced that anyone arriving on time all week would get a \$25 bonus on Friday. Clock-in times for Team A improved almost immediately — by Wednesday, only one worker had been late all week, down from an average of four late arrivals per person the month before.

With Team B, Dana instead announced that anyone late more than once in a week would lose their preferred parking spot for the following week — spots near the door that workers had specifically requested. Team B also improved, though more slowly: late arrivals dropped by about half in the first week and continued dropping through the second week.

Dana tracked both teams for a full month. Team A's improvement happened faster and lasted longer; Team B's improvement was real but a few workers seemed to "test" the rule again once the first week passed, requiring a reminder. Dana wrote in her log: "Adding something workers want seems to be outperforming removing something they want, at least for this group, this month."



Case File 2: The Barking Problem

A dog trainer, Marcus, is called in to help a family whose dog, Biscuit, barks constantly at the mail carrier. The family has tried yelling "no" at Biscuit every time he barks, but the barking has continued for three months with no improvement — if anything, it has gotten slightly worse, since Biscuit now seems to bark at Marcus's own arrival too.

Marcus explains that yelling is itself a form of attention, and for some dogs, attention functions as a reward even when it is meant as a correction — meaning the family may have been accidentally reinforcing the exact behavior they wanted to stop. Marcus proposes a different plan: the family will completely ignore Biscuit during mail delivery (removing the attention Biscuit seems to want), and separately, give Biscuit a treat and praise every time the mail carrier passes without barking (adding something Biscuit wants, when the desired behavior — staying quiet — occurs).

After two weeks of the new plan, Biscuit's barking at the mail carrier drops from nearly every delivery to about one bark in five deliveries. Marcus notes that the family's original approach was actually reinforcing barking rather than punishing it, even though it felt like a punishment to them.



Partner / lab discussion

Discuss each item with a partner or lab group before writing a joint response.

1. With a partner, discuss: why might Team B's improvement have been slower and less stable than Team A's, based only on evidence in the case, not outside knowledge?

2. With a partner, design an original one-sentence scenario that demonstrates negative reinforcement, then explain what makes it negative reinforcement rather than positive.

3. Discuss: is classical conditioning present anywhere in either case file? Use the lesson's definition of classical conditioning to justify your answer.



Independent practice

Work independently. Show your work or cite evidence in every answer.

1. Write an original one-sentence example of positive punishment, different from any example in the lesson or case files.

2. Write an original one-sentence example of negative punishment, different from any example in the lesson or case files.

3. A classmate says, "Negative always means bad and positive always means good." Correct this misconception using evidence from Case File 1.



Independent practice

Work independently. Show your work or cite evidence in every answer.

4. Explain why Marcus's plan uses two conditioning strategies at once (ignoring barking AND rewarding quiet) rather than just one.

5. If Dana wanted to combine both of her approaches for a new team, propose a plan using both positive reinforcement and negative punishment, and justify each part.

6. Predict what might happen to Team B's lateness rates if Dana stopped enforcing the parking-spot rule after one month, and justify your prediction using operant conditioning principles.



Small-group extension work

Use for review or additional application practice.

1. Identify one ethical consideration the lesson's cases raise about using punishment (positive or negative) versus reinforcement to change behavior.

2. Write a short original case (4-5 sentences) describing a workplace or classroom scenario, then correctly label the type of operant conditioning used.



Small-group extension work

Use for learners ready for additional challenge or synthesis.

1. Compare Case File 1 and Case File 2: what is one similarity in how positive reinforcement worked in each case, even though the subjects (workers vs. a dog) are very different?

2. Explain why timing matters in operant conditioning, using evidence from either case file to support your answer.



Assessment

Complete independently to show what you learned today.

1. Self-assessment: which of the four quadrants (positive reinforcement, negative reinforcement, positive punishment, negative punishment) do you feel least confident identifying, and why?



Assessment · self-assessment

Rate today's work:

4 — I can teach this to someone else.

3 — I can do this independently.

2 — I can do this with help.

1 — I need to revisit this before the next session.



Answer key

1. Positive reinforcement — a bonus (something desirable) was added, and the target behavior (on-time arrival) increased.
2. Negative punishment — a preferred parking spot (something desirable) was removed, and the target behavior being discouraged (lateness) decreased.
3. The lesson defines positive/negative by whether something is added or removed, not by whether the consequence feels pleasant; using "added/removed" language keeps the analysis precise instead of relying on a vaguer good/bad judgment.
4. They were unintentionally providing attention, which functioned as positive reinforcement for barking, even though it was intended as a punishment.
5. (a) Extinction/negative punishment of barking — removing the attention that had been reinforcing it; (b) positive reinforcement of quiet behavior — adding a treat/praise when the dog stays quiet.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

6. Because attention (even negative-sounding attention like yelling) can function as a reward for an attention-seeking dog; the actual effect on behavior — barking continuing or worsening — is what defines it as reinforcement, not the family's intent.
7. The case states a few Team B workers "tested" the rule again after the first week, suggesting the negative punishment needed reinforcement/reminders to hold, while Team A's positive reinforcement produced a faster, more sustained change in this specific case.
8. Answers vary; must show an unpleasant stimulus being removed when a behavior occurs, increasing that behavior — e.g., "A student turns in homework early and no longer has to hear reminder emails," which is negative because something was taken away, not added.
9. No — the lesson defines classical conditioning as pairing two stimuli (like a sound and food) rather than a behavior being followed by a consequence; both case files describe consequences following behaviors, which is operant, not classical, conditioning.
10. Answers vary; must show something added following a behavior, with the behavior intended to decrease, e.g., "A player is benched (extra running drills added) for missing curfew."

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

11. Answers vary; must show something removed following a behavior, with the behavior intended to decrease, e.g., "A teenager loses car privileges for missing curfew."

12. This is a common misconception; in operant conditioning "positive" means added and "negative" means removed, regardless of whether the outcome is pleasant. In Case File 1, negative punishment (removing a parking spot) is not "positive" just because it worked, and positive reinforcement is not automatically "nicer" than negative punishment — the words describe the mechanism, not the emotional tone.

13. Removing the reinforcement for barking (ignoring it) addresses the behavior to decrease, while separately reinforcing the desired opposite behavior (quiet) gives the dog a clear alternative that is rewarded — using both together builds a replacement behavior rather than just suppressing the old one.

14. Answers vary; must include one element that adds something for good behavior (e.g., a bonus for on-time weeks) and one that removes something for the undesired behavior (e.g., losing a privilege for repeated lateness), each explained using the added/removed logic.

15. Lateness would likely increase again, since removing the consequence (extinction) tends to weaken a conditioned behavior change over time unless a new consistent consequence or an intrinsic motivation has taken its place.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

16. Answers vary; must raise a genuine consideration, e.g., punishment can create resentment, fear, or only suppress a behavior temporarily without teaching a replacement behavior, while reinforcement of a desired alternative (as Marcus used) can be more sustainable and less aversive.

17. Answers vary; must include a behavior, a specific consequence, a stated outcome (behavior increases or decreases), and a correct two-word label matching the added/removed and increase/decrease logic.

18. In both cases, adding something the subject wanted (a bonus for workers; a treat/praise for Biscuit) immediately following the desired behavior increased that behavior — the mechanism works the same way across very different subjects.

19. A consequence generally must follow closely after the behavior to shape it effectively; in Case File 2, treats were given right when Biscuit stayed quiet during a delivery, connecting the reward directly to the desired moment rather than to some unrelated later time.

20. Answers vary; must name one specific quadrant and a genuine reason (e.g., confusing negative reinforcement with punishment because "negative" sounds bad).

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Access, sources, and license

Extension

Ask for a second method, a counterexample, or a short student-led extension of the concept, with a brief explanation of the choice.

Accommodated seating/504

Follow the individual accommodation plan: extended time, breaks, enlarged print, reduced copying, or an alternate response method as documented.

Additional support

Pre-teach key vocabulary or notation before class. Model the first guided item aloud. Accept oral or dictated responses when appropriate.

Multilingual learners

Preview key terms with examples. Allow brief first-language discussion before independent writing. Provide sentence or solution starters.

Course-level alignment · accessed September 18, 2026

COURSE-OBJ.PSY101.2 — Identify reinforcement and punishment (positive/negative) in real behavior-change scenarios and distinguish operant conditioning from classical conditioning. The objective is original wording describing a focused part of the course-level goal.

Course-level learning objective written for this packet; no accreditation, transfer credit, or universal course-equivalency is claimed.

Original reading(s)/worked examples, questions, and answer explanations. No textbook or copyrighted course material reproduced.

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